Your First Steps with AI

A Large-Print Guide for Seniors



Chatbots explained step by step

Everyday uses • Scam safety • Privacy

Independent guide - not affiliated with any AI company.
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Welcome

Your First Steps with AI explains, in plain language, what AI chatbots are and how to use three popular ones safely. Go at your own pace. There is no need to be "good with computers" - if you can send a text message, you can do this.

The three golden rules

1. AI can be wrong - check anything important.
2. Never share passwords, bank or ID numbers.
3. If a call or message rushes you to pay - stop, hang up, and check.

What is an AI chatbot?

An AI chatbot is a computer program you can talk to by typing or speaking. You ask a question in everyday words and it writes back an answer. It learned from a huge amount of text, so it is good at explaining, summarizing and drafting.

It is **not** a person, and it does not "know" things the way people do. It predicts helpful-sounding words, so it can sometimes sound confident and still be wrong.

Before you start

- A smartphone, tablet or computer connected to the internet.
- An email address (you may also be asked for a phone number to receive a code).
- Reading glasses if you need them - and a cup of tea.
- Tip: on a phone, use the official app from your phone's app store. Check the developer name matches the company (OpenAI, Google or Anthropic).

How to make text bigger

- On most phones: Settings > Display (or Accessibility) > Text size.
- On a computer browser: hold **Ctrl** (or **Cmd** on a Mac) and press **+**.

Getting started: ChatGPT (by OpenAI)

Where: chatgpt.com, or the ChatGPT app
Cost: a free version is available. Paid plans add more use and features - you do not need one to begin.

Step by step

1. Open the website or app. Sign up with an email address or phone number, or an existing account such as Google or Apple (options vary).
2. Follow the on-screen steps. You may get a code by email or text - type it in.
3. Find the message box at the bottom of the screen (it may say "Ask anything" or similar).
4. Type your question in normal words and press **Enter** or the arrow button.
5. Read the answer. Then ask a **follow-up** in the same box, like "Can you make that shorter?"

Talking instead of typing

Look for a **microphone** or **sound-wave** icon near the message box. Tap it, allow the microphone, and speak. (Varies by device and country.)

Getting started: Gemini (by Google)

Where: gemini.google.com, or the Google Gemini app
Cost: a free version is available. Paid plans add more use and features - you do not need one to begin.

Step by step

1. Open the website or app. Sign in with a Google account (the same one used for Gmail).
2. Follow the on-screen steps. You may get a code by email or text - type it in.
3. Find the message box at the bottom of the screen (it may say "Ask anything" or similar).
4. Type your question in normal words and press **Enter** or the arrow button.
5. Read the answer. Then ask a **follow-up** in the same box, like "Can you make that shorter?"

Talking instead of typing

Look for a **microphone** or **sound-wave** icon near the message box. Tap it, allow the microphone, and speak. (Varies by device and country.)

Getting started: Claude (by Anthropic)

Where: claude.ai, or the Claude app
Cost: a free version is available. Paid plans add more use and features - you do not need one to begin.

Step by step

1. Open the website or app. Sign up with an email address or an existing account such as Google (options vary).
2. Follow the on-screen steps. You may get a code by email or text - type it in.
3. Find the message box at the bottom of the screen (it may say "Ask anything" or similar).
4. Type your question in normal words and press **Enter** or the arrow button.
5. Read the answer. Then ask a **follow-up** in the same box, like "Can you make that shorter?"

Talking instead of typing

Look for a **microphone** or **sound-wave** icon near the message box. Tap it, allow the microphone, and speak. (Varies by device and country.)

Good questions get good answers

Give a little background, say what you want, and ask follow-ups. Examples to try:

- "Explain what a Roth IRA is in simple words, like you're talking to a friend."
- "Write a short, warm birthday message for my granddaughter who loves horses."
- "I have chicken, rice and spinach. Give me an easy dinner recipe for two."
- "Plan a relaxed 3-day trip to the coast with lots of rest stops."
- "Help me write a polite email asking my landlord to fix the heating."
- "What questions should I ask my doctor about a new prescription?" (then ask your doctor!)

Follow-up phrases that help: "Make it simpler." "Use bigger steps." "Give me 3 options." "Why?" "Start again."

Know the limits

- **It can be wrong.** AI sometimes invents facts, dates or sources. Double-check important information with a trusted source.
- **Health, money and legal matters:** use AI to prepare questions - then speak to a qualified professional.
- **It may be out of date** unless it searches the web - check the date of anything time-sensitive.
- **It is not a friend or advisor.** It can be kind and helpful, but it does not replace people you trust.

Good habits that help

• Ask: "How sure are you? Where could I check this?"
• Look up important facts on an official website.
• Ask a family member or friend when something feels off.
• Take a break - there is never a rush.

Spotting AI-powered scams

Criminals now use AI to copy voices, faces and writing styles. Watch for these:

Voice-clone phone calls

A call that sounds exactly like a grandchild or relative "in trouble" asking for money. A few seconds of someone's voice online can be enough to copy it.

Deepfake videos and photos

Videos of celebrities or officials promoting investments, miracle cures or giveaways. If it promises easy money, it is a scam.

Fake tech or bank support

Pop-ups, calls or messages saying your computer or account has a problem and asking you to call a number, install an app or share a code.

"Send it through the app"

Scammers often ask you to pay with a **payment app** - the kind of phone app people use to send money straight to a friend or split a dinner bill. Money sent this way usually **cannot be recovered**. Only use these apps with people you know in person. A real bank, government office or company will never ask you to pay a fine or "move your money to keep it safe" through an app.

Red flags - stop if you see any:

- Urgency: "Act now" or "Don't tell anyone."
- Payment by gift card, wire transfer, cryptocurrency, a payment app or courier.
- Requests for passwords or one-time codes.
- A caller who won't let you hang up and call back.

Your family safe-word

Agree on a secret word with family that only you know. If a caller claims to be a relative in an emergency, ask for the safe-word. No word? Hang up and call that person on the number you already have. Keep the word in your memory - don't write it down or share it online.

Your scam-call script

1. Say: "I'll call you right back."
2. Hang up - even if the voice sounds just like family.
3. Call the person on a number you already know.
4. Tell another family member or a friend.
5. Never pay by gift card, wire, crypto or payment app.

If you already paid

- Call your bank or the payment company **right away** - the sooner, the better.
- Report it at **ReportFraud.ftc.gov** (United States).
- Tell someone you trust. Scams happen to smart, careful people.

Privacy: what not to share

Treat a chatbot like a public place - don't type anything you wouldn't want a stranger to read.

Never share	Okay to share
Passwords and PINs Bank, card and Social Security / ID numbers One-time codes Full medical records Your home address with travel dates	General questions Recipes, hobbies, travel ideas Drafts of letters (remove names and numbers) Questions about how things work

Helpful settings

- Look in the app's **Settings** for privacy or data controls - for example, options about saving chat history or using chats to improve the AI.
- You can usually delete past conversations.
- Log out on shared or public computers.

Glossary

AI (artificial intelligence)	Computer programs that do tasks that usually need human thinking.
Chatbot	An AI program you talk to by typing or speaking.
Prompt	The question or instruction you give the chatbot.
Follow-up	A new message that builds on the last answer.
App	A program on your phone or tablet.
Account	Your personal sign-in for a service.
Free plan / paid plan	Free versions have limits; paid plans give more use and features.
Deepfake	A fake video, photo or voice made with AI.
Voice clone	AI copying a real person's voice.
Phishing	Messages that trick you into sharing information or money.
Payment app	A phone app for sending money directly to another person. Payments are hard to reverse.
Hallucination	When AI makes up something that isn't true.

My notes

Questions to ask, ideas to try and helpful numbers. (Please don't write your family safe-word here.)

My bank's fraud phone number: _____

Important notes

This guide is for general education only. It is not technical, legal, financial or medical advice. Features, prices and availability of AI services change often and vary by country and device; always follow the instructions on the official website or app.

ChatGPT is a trademark of OpenAI; Gemini is a trademark of Google LLC; Claude is a trademark of Anthropic; all other names belong to their respective owners. This guide is independent and is not affiliated with, endorsed or sponsored by any of these companies. Information checked October 2026 - apps change often, so screens and plans may look different.

If you think you have been targeted by a scam, contact your bank right away. In the United States, report it to the Federal Trade Commission at **ReportFraud.ftc.gov** and to your state attorney general. Elsewhere, contact your local consumer protection agency or police.